4.4.2 Basic Democracy

Basic Democracy was a peculiar and controversial system that Ayub Khan invented. The critics of Ayub Khan observed the system as was a form of "representational dictatorship." It offered for an indirect election system.

Ayub Khan did not believe that a sophisticated parliamentary democracy was suitable for Pakistan since there were vast number of illiterate people.

President Ayub Khan has issued an ordinance in October 1959 for setting up 'basic democracies' or small units of local self-government in the country. There will be around 1,20,000 such units, each representing from 1000 to 15000 citizens. Ayub Khan said,

> Democracy has brought to the very doorstep of the people making it possible for them to know its real meaning in terms of managing and developing their village or mohalla as they would manage and develop their own home or family. Indeed for the first time in the history of Pakistan, our people will be able to elect as their representatives men and women whom they know from personal knowledge to be good, honest and competent.

The Basic Democracies system set up five tiers of institutions. The lowest but most important tier was composed of union councils, one each for groups of villages having an approximate total population of 10,000. Each union council comprised ten directly elected members and five appointed members, all called Basic Democrats (BD member). Union councils were responsible for local agricultural and community development and for rural law and order maintenance; they were empowered to impose local taxes for local projects.

The next tier consisted of the *tehsil* (sub-district) councils, which performed coordination functions. Above them, the district (*zilla*) councils, chaired by the deputy commissioners, were composed of nominated official and nonofficial members, including the chairmen of union councils. The district councils were assigned both compulsory and optional functions pertaining to education, sanitation, local culture, and social welfare. Above them, the divisional advisory councils coordinated the activities with representatives of government departments. The highest tier consisted of one development advisory

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council for each province, chaired by the governor and appointed by the president. The urban areas had a similar arrangement, under which the smaller union councils were grouped together into municipal committees to perform similar duties.

In 1960 an election was held under the ordinance of this system. 80,000 (from East Pakistan 40,000 and another 40,000 from West Pakistan) Basic democrats were elected. The elected members of the union councils voted to confirm Ayub Khan's presidency, and under the 1962 constitution they formed an electoral college to elect the president, the National Assembly, and the provincial assemblies.

4.4.3 Education Movement of 1962

One of the notorious steps, which was a part of Ayub's grand conspiracy of subduing the Bengalis is the formation of an Education Commission. In an ordinance, he constituted an Education Commission chaired by S.M. Sharif (Education Secretary of West Pakistan) on December 30, 1958. In August 26, 1959 the commission submitted its report. The recommendations of the report were so harmful for the students of East Pakistan that they burst into agitation ignoring the life risks under the Marshall Law when the results of public exams were published under the partial implementation of this law. However, the report recommended the following steps:

a) Encouragement should be given to the development of residential secondary schools;
b) Secondary school curriculum should include a core of compulsory subjects along with a few optional ones with a technical and vocational bias;
c) The conducting of Intermediate courses should be vested upon the Boards of Secondary Education instead of the universities;
d) The degree courses both pass and honors, should be of three years duration;
e) Comprehensive' scholarship programs for the gifted students should stretch from beyond the primary stage to the top and;
f) Provision should be made for adequate facilities for female education.

The Commission also suggested for a few basic changes in the administrative set-up, such as decentralizing the management of

primary education, revamping the examination system, and envisaging a new management structure for technical education. The report claims that the steps recommended by the commission have the following objectives:

To develop—

i. a good worker,
ii. a good citizen,
iii. a good individual and
iv. a good patriot.

However, the report was rejected by the students and the scholars of East Pakistan. As a result, they launched a movement against the report and demanded for the withdrawal.

The students' movement took a new turn on August 10 when college students assembled in a meeting at Dhaka College. It includes month long programs. On September 10 a meeting was held at the Dhaka University cafeteria where almost all the colleges of the city were represented. The meeting withdrew the previously announced sit-down strike but announced a fresh action program of hartal or total strike on September 17. It was the first general strike during Ayub Khan's tyrannical rule. Army was deployed in the Dhaka city; Section 144 was promulgated. A few college students including Quazi Faruque Ahmed initiated the movement at college level. Gradually student leaders at university level joined them, and made the movement wide. The student movement spread to entire Bangladesh, then East Pakistan. In Dhaka, shops, bazaars, educational institutions, semi-government offices remained closed. Attendance in government offices was thin. On September 17, the participants in the Dhaka procession were not only students, but also industrial workers, rickshaw pullers and boatmen. In the morning of September 17, when a procession was crossing Abdul Gani road in Dhaka, police opened fire. Babul, a student of Nabokumar High School was killed, and bus conductor Golam Mostofa, domestic worker Waziullah and many others seriously injured. Waziullah later died in the hospital.

During the clash between police and public in Jessore, 41 police constables and the police super was injured. In Chittagong, army was called in following clashes between police and public. More than 100 persons including 50 policemen were injured.

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When the situation turned to hostility, opposition leader H. S. Suhrawardy came to Dhaka from Karachi and met East Pakistan Governor Golam Faruk. He succeeded to convince the governor to suspend the implementation of the recommendations of the Sharif Commission Report. Thus, the students' movement in 1962 succeeded completely. It is said that the '52-language movement cultivated the spirit of Bengali nationalism and the '62-education movement indoctrinated and inculcated the ingredient of progressive content in it.

4.4.4 Six Point Movement

The placement of the Six Points demand by Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman on 5 February, 1966[34] in the conference of the all Pakistan opposition parties at Lahore was a milestone in the history of the liberation movement in Bangladesh. It took the movement to the final stage. When his demand of six points was not permitted to place within the agenda of that meeting, he boycotted the conference and withdrew is representation from the meeting. Thereafter, in an off the cuff press conference in Lahore airport on February 10, he said," The question of autonomy appears to be more important after the war (Indo-Pakistan war in September, 1965). The time has come for making East Pakistan self-sufficient in all respects." He then enunciated a 'six-point charter of survival' (Aamader Bachar Dabi: Chhoy Dofa) program for East Pakistan.

On his return to Dhaka on February 11, 1966, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman provided further clarification on his six-point formula in a press conference. He explained why he had disassociated himself from the All-Party conference in Lahore. He emphasized that the immediate adoption and implementation of his six-point formula "will be conducive to foster durable relationship between the two provinces of Pakistan". In a press conference on February 14, 1966, he also repeated what he had uttered in his Lahore press conference: that "the question of autonomy appears to be more important for East Pakistan after the 17-day war between Pakistan and India."

Even, the senior leaders of Awami league initially did not aware of the demand. Later, some of them left Awami League on the question of 'Six Points'. However, the charter grew overwhelming inspiration among the people of East Pakistan. People considered the charter as the 'Magna Carta' of Bengali nation.

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[34] *The Daily Ittefaq*, February 12, 1966.

The six points are as follows:

1. The Constitution should provide for a Federation of Pakistan in its true sense on the Lahore Resolution, and the parliamentary form of government with supremacy of a Legislature directly elected on the basis of universal adult franchise.
2. The federal government should deal with only two subjects: Defense and Foreign Affairs, and all other residuary subjects shall be vested in the federating states.
3. Two separate, but freely convertible currencies for two wings should be introduced; or if this is not feasible, there should be one currency for the whole country, but effective constitutional provisions should be introduced to stop the flight of capital from East to West Pakistan. Furthermore, a separate Banking Reserve should be established, and separate fiscal and monetary policy be adopted for East Pakistan.
4. The power of taxation and revenue collection shall be vested in the federating units and the federal centre will have no such power on the issue. The federation will be entitled to a share in the state taxes to meet its expenditures.
5. There should be two separate accounts for the foreign exchange earnings of the two wings; the foreign exchange requirements of the federal government should be met by the two wings equally or in a ratio to be fixed; indigenous products should move free of duty between the two wings, and the Constitution should empower the units to establish trade links with foreign countries.
6. East Pakistan should have a separate militia or paramilitary force.

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4.4.5 Reactions to Six Point Movement

No sooner had the 6-point program been published than Ayub Khan declared it 'secessionist' and styled its author Bangabandhu as the enemy number one of Pakistan. Ayub also threatened to use brute force to suppress this charter of demands. But Awami League and its leader Sheikh Mujibur Rahman remained undaunted by such threats. Bangabandhu started a 3-month long mass-contact program which took him to every nook and corner of Bangladesh. Mujib was arrested eight times in the first three months of the 6-point movement. By then, Bangabandhu had become the President of Awami League. He was finally thrown into jail on May 8, 1966, a general strike was observed all over East Pakistan in support of the 6-point program and for the release of Mujib. Police fired in Tejgaon, Tongi and Narayanganj killing 13 people. This was followed by large-scale arrests of the leaders and followers of Awami League throughout the country. All these measures taken by the Ayub regime proved counter-productive. 6-point program became the heartfelt demand of the common masses. Students put forward their 11-point program, which complemented the 6-point charter of demands. Thus the political situation in East Pakistan became extremely volatile: the stage was set for a great explosion of popular anger through an all-out mass-movement against the Ayub rule.

4.4.6 Why Six Point is called as Magna Carta?

The six point of Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman was widely compared with the 'Magna Carta.' The Magna Carta is a document that dates back to the year 1215. The name is Latin for 'Great Charte'. In that year English King John declared a charter in which defined the rights of King John, who ruled England at the time, a group of wealthy men called barons and the Catholic Church in England. Throughout history the document's meaning has expanded to include other people as well. In the six points declared by Bangabandhu included such steps, which was essential for the freedom of the people of East Pakistan. That's why; it is widely called as the 'Magna Carta' of Bengali nation.

4.4.7 Significance of Six Point Movement

The historic Six Point is very significant in the history of the liberation movement of Bangladesh. After the declaration of the

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charter, it became clear who were actually Bengali nationalists and who were not. The steps demanded in the points were so sound that the people easily understand their status and their vision. It officially expressed the full autonomy, however, the West Pakistani leaders and the Muslim league branded it as the separatist movement. People were also fed up with the Pakistani rule. So, the blame against Sheikh Mujib was also greated by the people because they already took the role of Sheikh Mujib as a great nationalist leader.

President of Pakistan Ayub Khan challenged to face the movement with arms. People did not accept this threat cordially rather they took the threat against Sheikh Mujib as the threat against them. Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujib gave speech in 32 public meetings with 50 days and explained Six Points. It's a record in the history of the political campaign in Bengal. Sheikh Mujibs campaign for Six Points made an example of systematic movement through which he was succeeded to create a mass mobilization for the Six Points. Therefore, when Bangabandhu and his followers were put behind bars on May 8, 1966, along with his other followers it was vehemently resented by the people, and the whole of Bangladesh protested like one entity by holding meetings,rallies and processions which rocked the distant capital atRawalpindi.

On May 20, the Awami League Working Committee decided to organize a protest meeting on June 7, 1966 by condemning repression and demanding release of Bangabandhu and other leaders, and thus came the observance of strike on 7th June. The day dawned with factories remaining closed, transport off the roads and business houses shut down. This was the way people tried to express their indignation against the oppressors and resolute support to the leadership of Bangabandhu. People came out on the streets closing their establishments, offices and shops. They suspended all their normal activities. Dhaka became the city of processions and slogans. The workers and students brought out peaceful processions. But the regime of exploiters could not tolerate slogan-chanting people who had made a sacred vow to realize their right to self-determination and so the ruling clique responded with the language of weapons killing scores of people including Monu Mia in Dhaka and Narayanganj. Thus the people of Bangladesh raised their slogans for independence

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